BASS & MELODY WRITING

Pacing guide · 4 days

PACING

Teacher

Four class periods of about 53 minutes, as in my course plan: an intro day, two work days and a presenting day. The melody comes first, then the bassline. Each day's full plan is on pages 7–8.

DAY	FOCUS AND GOAL	MINUTE BLOCKS	DECK
DAY 1 Intro day	**Scales + melody start** Every student has checked or built the C major and A natural minor scales, chosen a key, and started a 2- or 4-measure melody over the chords and bassline.	0–8 · The hook 8–12 · Bright or dark? 12–25 · Scales 25–32 · Two projects, four ways 32–38 · Watch me 38–50 · Write 50–53 · Save + hum it	Intro deck slides 1–10
DAY 2 Work day	**Finish the melody, meet the bass rule** Melody projects submitted. Every student has looked hard at a bassline and found the rule before you say it.	0–5 · Does it belong? 5–10 · What you turn in 10–17 · Mixing moment: frequency separation 17–35 · Finish + submit the melody 35–47 · Basslines: look before you write 47–53 · The reveal	Intro deck slides 11–15
DAY 3 Work day	**Plan + build the bassline** Progression planned with Roman numerals and root notes; chords and a monophonic bassline built in Logic and submitted.	0–12 · Plan your progression 12–18 · Watch me: roots first 18–45 · Build 45–50 · What you turn in 50–53 · Export + submit	Intro deck slides 16–20
DAY 4 Present	**Presentations** Every student presents; every student can say what key, what Roman numerals, and what they wanted it to feel like.	0–5 · Last checks 5–48 · Presentations 48–53 · Close	Intro deck slides 21–22

STUDENT PAGES BY DAY ·

Day 1	Melody post (p. 13), packet Part 2 (p. 15), Reference Cards (pp. 17–18), four ways (p. 19), melody project sheet (pp. 20–21)
Day 2	Melody rubric (p. 22), basslines post (p. 14, steps 1–3), packet Part 4 analysis (p. 16)
Day 3	Basslines post steps 4–5, bassline project sheet with the planning table (pp. 23–24), rubric (p. 25)
Day 4	Vocabulary (p. 26) and the two rubrics for scoring

MY LINE FOR THE WHOLE UNIT

"Simple and repetitive will always beat complicated and forgettable." Say it on Day 1. Say it again when a student plays you a melody that goes nowhere because they tried to use every note in the scale.

PREVIEW

BASS & MELODY WRITING

Four ways to write a melody

STUDENT

Day 1

Name _____ Date _____

There is more than one way to write a melody. Try at least two of these today. Whichever you use, the rules are the same: 2 or 4 measures, notes from your scale, start or end on the root.

1 PLAY IT IN

Loop 2 measures with Cycle (C). Press R, play on the white keys, stop. Select the notes and press Q to quantize.

Good when you can already hear an idea in your head.

2 DRAW A RHYTHM FIRST

With the Pencil, click notes in a rhythm you like, all on the root. Play it back. Then drag some notes up or down to other scale notes.

Good when you have a groove but no tune yet.

3 CLICK ONE NOTE, MOVE IT

Click in one note. Listen. Drag it up or down until it fits the chord. Then click the next one.

Good when you want to build slowly, one decision at a time.

4 USE THE STEP SEQUENCER

Control-click the track lane and choose Create Pattern Region. Turn steps on to place notes; each row is one pitch.

Good when you want a short, repeating, rhythmic hook.

STUCK?

Use only 3 notes. C major: C, E, G · A minor: A, C, E. Go up, then come back down. That is a melody.

REMEMBER

Simple and repetitive will always beat complicated and forgettable.

The two methods I tried: _____

The one that worked best for me, and why: _____

PREVIEW

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

PACKET

The Scary Stuff · Part 4: Basslines

Part 4 · Days 2–3

Name _____ Date _____

Open the Logic file your teacher provides. A bassline is already written. Before you do anything else, answer the questions below.

LOOK AT THE BASSLINE IN THE PIANO ROLL. ANSWER THESE QUESTIONS ·

What key is this bassline in? _____

What chord is playing in the first section? _____

What note does the bassline play during that chord? _____

Is that note the root of the chord? _____

What happens to the bass note when the chord changes? _____

Write the Roman numeral for each chord in the progression:

Chord 1: _____ **Chord 2:** _____ **Chord 3:** _____ **Chord 4:** _____

THE RULE

When the chord changes, the bass note changes to the root of the new chord.

Everything else — rhythm, extra notes, movement between roots — is decoration on top of this one rule.

NOW WRITE YOUR OWN BASSLINE ·

Choose a chord progression from your Reference Card. Write the Roman numerals and root notes below, then build it in Logic.

CHORD 1	CHORD 2	CHORD 3	CHORD 4
Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____
Root note: _____	Root note: _____	Root note: _____	Root note: _____

Why did you choose this progression? What did you want it to feel like?

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Rubric · bassline

RUBRIC

/ 15

Name _____ Date _____

PART 4: BASSLINES — RUBRIC

The Building Blocks · Unit 4 · /15

Each category is scored from 2 to 5.

Category	2	3	4	5	Score
BASSLINE CONSTRUCTION	Bassline not monophonic, or root notes absent or wrong. Does not follow chord progression.	Bassline mostly monophonic with some correct root notes, but does not consistently follow chord changes.	Bassline is monophonic. Root note used at each chord change. Some rhythmic variation present.	Bassline is monophonic, follows every chord change, and has a clear rhythmic identity. Feels like it belongs.	
HARMONIC INTENTION	Chord choices appear random. No written explanation or explanation shows no harmonic thinking.	Progression uses correct chords but written explanation is vague. No clear emotional intention.	Progression has a discernible feel. Written explanation describes what student intended.	Progression has a clear emotional character. Student can explain their choices using Roman numeral language.	
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	Not submitted or not presented.	Submitted late or named incorrectly. Minimal presentation engagement.	Correctly named and submitted. Presentation made. Planning table completed.	Correctly named, on time. Student presents chord choices using Roman numeral language confidently.	
				TOTAL	**/ 15**

I CHOSE MY PROGRESSION BECAUSE...

_____

_____

_____

TEACHER COMMENTS

_____

_____

_____

PREVIEW

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